Template

Empathy map canvas

Use this framework to empathize with a customer, user, or any person who is affected by a team's work. Document and discuss your observations and note your assumptions to gain more empathy for the people you serve.

Originally created by Dave Gray at

XPLANE®

Share template feedback

Develop shared understanding and empathy

Summarize the data you have gathered related to the people that are impacted by your work. It will help you generate ideas, prioritize features, or discuss decisions.

WHO are we empathizing with?

Who is the person we want to understand?
What is the situation they are in?
What is their role in the situation?

SituationFaces 200+ security alerts daily, ~60% are false positives — overwhelmed and unable to focus on real threats

Sayali SOC Analyst (Level 2) at a mid-size IT company — responsible for monitoring network traffic and responding to threats

ContextUses legacy rule-based tools (Snort/Splunk) that miss novel attacks and generate excessive noise

RolePrimary user of the IDS — reviews alerts, investigates incidents, escalates confirmed threats to management

What influences the user?

- Management saying "we cannot afford a security incident this quarter".

Peers recommending ML-based anomaly detection tools

Security conferences promoting AI-driven threat intelligence

Vendors claiming 99% accuracy — but rarely in real environments

News about competitors being hit by cyberattacks

What do they THINK and FEEL?

PAINS

- What are their fears, frustrations, and anxieties?
- Frustrations and obstacles

High false positive rates slow down the entire security team

Existing systems can't detect novel or zero-day attacks

GAINS

- What are their wants, needs, hopes, and dreams?
- Goals and desired outcomes

Fewer false positives so analysts focus on real threats

A live dashboard showing attack type, severity, and source

What other thoughts and feelings might influence their behavior?

Ability to detect DoS, Probe, R2L, and U2R attacks accurately

Manual log analysis is time-consuming and error-prone

GOAL

Do differently Stop manually reviewing every alert — let an AI system pre-classify threats so only genuine ones need attention

Job to be done Detect, classify, and respond to network intrusions in real time — covering DoS, Probe, R2L, and U2R attacks

What do they need to DO?

What do they need to do differently?
What job(s) do they want or need to get done?
What decision(s) do they need to make?
How will we know they were successful?

Decisions to make Which alerts are real threats vs false positives? What severity level? Escalate or resolve independently?

Success looks like<5% false positive rate, real threats detected in <1 minute, clear dashboard showing all incidents at a glance

Dashboards with limited drill-down or ML-based classification

Legacy IDS tools that flag normal traffic as threats

Colleagues spending hours manually verifying low-priority alerts

News about rising ransomware and DDoS attacks globally

What the user observes daily?

- Hundreds of network log entries and alerts every day

What the user voices aloud?

- We need a smarter system that can detect threats we haven't seen before.

I spend half my day chasing false alarms.

The current IDS doesn't understand context — it just matches signatures.

We need real-time alerts, not reports after the breach.

What do they DO?

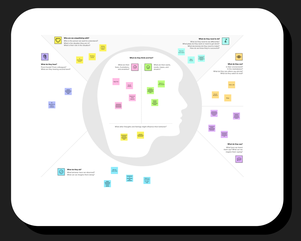
What do they do today?
What behavior have we observed?
What can we imagine them doing?

TodayLogs into Snort/Splunk every morning, manually scrolls through 200+ alerts, spends 1–2 hrs filtering false alarms before finding real issues

Observed behavior Applies mental heuristics to triage alerts — experience-based, not data-driven. Often misses low-and-slow attacks buried in noise

Behavior with AI IDS Opens the SOC dashboard → sees pre-classified alerts by type and severity → investigates only high-confidence threats → responds in minutes

Imagined actions Uses the Chart.js threat timeline to spot attack patterns, exports logs for compliance reports, shares dashboard screenshots with management



Need some inspiration?

See a finished version of this template to kickstart your work.

Open example